

Investigating the Influence of a Joint Sponsorship of Rival Teams on Supporter Attitudes and Brand Preferences

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ABSTRACT *The sponsorship of football is a multi-million pound industry. Sponsors hope that supporters' enthusiasm for their team will translate into long-term benefits for the sponsor. However, the intensity of team rivalry means that a sponsorship may also alienate opposing supporters. The rival Glasgow clubs, Celtic and Rangers, therefore undertook a joint sponsorship arrangement with the communications company NTL. This paper investigates how the benefits obtained compared to those that may have been expected from a single sponsorship. While the sponsorship was very effective in creating awareness for NTL, ambivalent attitudes were found towards the company. The most committed supporters were the least accepting of the sponsorship and the expected positive relationship between support for the club and brand preference for NTL was not found.*

KEY WORDS: Sponsorship, football, sports marketing, brand preference

Introduction

The sponsorship of football teams, leagues, events and players is a multi-million pound industry. Football is the most popular spectator sport in the UK and most teams have a loyal fan base of committed supporters who are highly involved with the team and the sport, not just watching their team play but positively seeking opportunities for associating themselves with it. Sponsoring football therefore gives companies the opportunity of increasing their exposure in terms of both reach and frequency and sponsorship managers hope that fans' goodwill towards their team will translate into positive attitudes and then purchase intentions towards the sponsoring brand. However, the downside is that strong emotional commitment towards a favoured team is frequently balanced by highly negative attitudes towards

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1352-7266 Print/1466-4445 Online/06/010031-18 © 2006 Taylor & Francis

DOI: 10.1080/13527260500264574

rival teams, which are usually based in a similar geographical area, e.g. Manchester United and Manchester City, Liverpool and Everton, Glasgow Celtic and Glasgow Rangers, Heart of Midlothian and Hibernian in Edinburgh, Swansea and Cardiff in South Wales and multiple rivalries in London. Sponsorship that is effective in associating the sponsor with a particular team may alienate opposition fans against the sponsor.

This paper focuses on Celtic and Rangers in Glasgow. Although these two football teams were very friendly in the beginning (Murray, 1984), very few if any other sporting organizations across the world encapsulate such rivalry today. Cultural, religious and emotional differences have caused severe problems with past sponsorship arrangements and so in 1999 the clubs began a 4-year, £13 million joint shirt sponsorship arrangement with the telecommunications company NTL in order to maximize revenue for both clubs. NTL's main objective at that time was to raise awareness of the company and this was achieved successfully. However, the contract was not renewed, perhaps because management were not convinced that these high levels of awareness were translating into increased revenues (www.pressbox.co.uk, 2003). However, the two clubs were able to set up a similar arrangement with Carling Lager, part of the Coors Group. To the authors' knowledge, no other pairs of rival football clubs have attempted such joint sponsorship agreements.

The intention of this paper is to examine the effects of the joint sponsorship arrangement on the attitudes and intentions of supporters of both teams and to compare these with what would be expected from a single team sponsorship. The literature review discusses the objectives of and benefits to companies undertaking sport sponsorship and examines the factors that affect and modify consumers' responses to sponsorship. These are then considered in the context of football. The empirical study that follows was carried out among Celtic and Rangers fans in 2002.

Sport Sponsorship: Objectives and Benefits

Walliser (2003) observed that there is no single accepted definition of sponsorship, but that

agreement exists that sponsorship is based on an exchange between sponsor and sponsored, and pursues marketing (communication) objectives by exploiting the association between the two (p. 8-9).

Consumers see sponsorship as a more subtle and indirect form of communication, to which they are likely to respond with more goodwill and less scepticism than they would to advertising (Meenaghan, 2001). Lagae (2005) pointed out the wide range of activities and agreements that come under the broad heading of 'sport sponsorship', from the simple displaying of brand names and logos to packages that 'contain the most important elements of the sports promotion mix' (p. 39). Sport is by far the most developed area of sponsorship, accounting for 54% of all sponsorship activity in the UK in 2001 (Intel, 2002) and Lagae (2005, pp. 6 and 43) suggested several reasons for this. Sport involves both fans and participants in a highly personal and

emotional way and transcends cultural and geographical barriers. Its globalization has been aided by increased worldwide television coverage, making sport a valuable partner for international brands. Sport and business share values such as the importance of teamwork, strategy and striving towards a goal. Thus, as sport becomes increasingly professional and commercialized, sport and business managers should have some understanding of each other's objectives.

Such objectives for sponsors may be divided into the three categories of awareness, image and sales (Cornwell and Maignan, 1998). The extent of televised coverage of sport, with the opportunities this provides for the display of a brand name or logo on players' clothing and signage around the ground or course, means that high-profile sport can be a highly effective medium for placing a brand in front of a massive audience. In order to ensure that this audience actually notices and remembers the brand, sponsors must draw attention to the sponsorship through associated marketing activities (Amis *et al.*, 1999). Awareness may be interpreted either as awareness of the sponsor *per se* or awareness of the particular sponsorship.

Image transfer or enhancement is achieved through association with a sponsored property that already generates a positive response among the target market. This is a major advantage of sport as a sponsored property, due to the intense emotions and strong images it evokes. The characteristics transferred may be global or specific (Keller, 1993). Meenaghan and Shipley (1999) found that consumers saw brands sponsoring sport as being 'healthy, young, energetic, fast, vibrant, [and] masculine' (p. 342), while Lagae (2005) cited the marathon sponsorship by the international bank ING as transferring values of 'endurance, discipline and effort' (p. 45) to the brand. Dean (1999) suggested that consumer goodwill towards the sponsored property might also create a 'halo effect' (Dion and Berscheid, 1972), i.e. increased goodwill towards the sponsor and a perception of superior quality. However, the converse is that an association with a sponsored property perceived negatively by the target market may tarnish a sponsor's image. Jenkins and Fleming's (2002) study of supporters of pairs of rival football teams found significant alienation among fans towards the rival team's sponsor.

While there are obvious difficulties in measuring the direct impact of sponsorship activity on sales (Pope, 1998), sponsors are likely to expect that greater awareness and a more positive image will translate to sales increases in the long term. Carlsberg, for example, which invests heavily in football sponsorship, achieved an increase in lager sales during the second week of the Euro '96 football tournament of 69%, against an industry increase of 55% (Easton and Mackie, 1998). Pitts and Slattery (2004) sounded a warning note, with over 60% of the respondents in their study of sponsorship recognition denying that sponsorship would make them more likely to buy a company's products: however, that still leaves a sizeable minority who allowed that sponsorship could affect their purchase decisions.

Factors Affecting Consumer Responses to Sponsorship

Various studies have investigated how the interrelationships between a consumer, sponsor and sponsored property affect the consumer's attitudinal and/or behavioural response to a particular sponsorship. These are summarized in Table 1.

Table 1. Factors affecting consumer responses to sponsorship

Factors found to affect responses	Authors
Congruence or 'fit' between sponsor and sponsored property	Ferrand and Pages (1996), Kinney and McDaniel (1996), Gwinner (1997), Gwinner and Eaton (1999), Speed and Thompson (2000) and Roy and Graeff (2002)
Consumer attitudes towards sponsored property	Lee <i>et al.</i> (1997) and Speed and Thompson (2000)
Consumer attitudes towards commercialization	Lee <i>et al.</i> (1997)
Consumer attitudes towards behavioural intent	Lee <i>et al.</i> (1997)
Perceived sincerity of sponsor	Speed and Thompson (2000)
Perceived ubiquity of sponsor (negative relationship)	Speed and Thompson (2000)
Perceived status of sponsored property	Speed and Thompson (2000)
Strong emotional response to sponsored property (event)	Quester and Farrelly (1998)
High identification/emotional involvement with sponsored property (team)	Bennett (1999) and Madrigal (2001)
Extent of exposure to sponsorship	Lardinoit and Derbaix (2001)
High identification with rival team (negative relationship)	Jenkins and Fleming (2002)

Congruence or 'fit' between a sponsor and sponsored property and a consumer's strong emotional involvement with the sponsored property appear to be key predictors of a positive response.

Team Identification in Football

Given the importance of team identification to sponsorship response, its nature is now briefly examined with respect to UK football, a sport that generates passion and strong loyalties. Supporters have been classified on both attitudinal and behavioural measures. Guilanotti (2002) proposed four categories (supporters, followers, fans and flaneurs). While both supporters and fans are characterized by a high level of passion for their chosen team, the formers' identification with the team is rooted in culture and community, while fans rely on the media for connecting them with their team, so their fan experience is based on market-centred relationships. Tapp and Clowes (2002) extended a basic attendance-based segmentation in order to identify several sub-segments, differentiated by attitude to the game, level of commitment and extent to which support was directed to a single team or a 'repertoire' of teams. At the 'fanatic' level they found respondents whose self-image was highly linked to their identity as a supporter of football or their particular team. While 'regular' supporters demonstrated commitment to their club, football was less important in defining their self-image. Many 'casual' supporters also maintained that they were loyal and committed to their club, but football played a smaller part in their lives.

The NTL and Carling Sponsorships

From *NTL 1999 Annual Report* (www.ntl.com), it appears the initial objective of the joint sponsorship was to raise awareness of the company as a new entrant in the telecommunications market and in this respect the sponsorship was a success, with brand awareness over the sponsorship period rising from 24% to 96% (Hannan, 2003). This awareness was created by the prominently displayed NTL logo on the teams' football shirts and by the extensive media coverage of Celtic and Rangers, in which NTL would feature prominently. The company believed that each £1 of sponsorship had generated between £1.50 and £1.70 worth of media coverage (Hannan, 2003). In addition, NTL was shown as a sponsor on the official club websites, with a link to the NTL site and the NTL suites at the club grounds were used regularly for corporate hospitality. In 2000 Rangers and the NTL subsidiary Premium TV set up a joint venture agreement for a pay-per-view Rangers television channel (still in existence). Celtic, however, turned down Premium TV's offer of a similar agreement because they felt the £31 million offered by the company was too low (Ashton, 2003).

Having achieved a dramatic increase in awareness, NTL naturally wanted to convert this into profits. By 2001 a 'healthy number of supporters' were NTL customers (managing director Ian Jeffers, quoted in Wilson, 2001), but increasing this number and quantifying the sponsorship benefits in terms of revenue was more problematic. The company used direct mail, promotional competitions in newspapers and through the websites and product demonstration days to attract customers, but the high level of response to such activities failed to translate into new customers. According to NTL's former sponsorship manager, Fraser McCulloch, the company 'just assumed that fans would let us sell to them because we sponsored their team. We forgot to expressly ask their permission first' (www.pressbox.co.uk, 2003). NTL's sponsorship strategy for Scotland now attempts to get closer to its customers by being oriented towards local communities, e.g. its sponsorship of the Learning Centre zone at the Glasgow Science Centre (Hannan, 2003).

Examination of the award-winning Carling sponsorship (Scottish Sport's Best First Time Sponsor 2004) highlights several differences from NTL. Firstly, this shirt sponsorship is only a part of Carling's massive involvement in football, in which it invested £15 million in 2004. Previous sponsors of the English Premiership, they now sponsor the Carling Cup and associated themselves with the Euro 2004 tournament through the 'Carling. Love Football' promotional campaign. This includes television commercials, a dedicated website with special pages for Rangers and Celtic and many opportunities for fan involvement through competitions with prizes that include commentating at games, joining team photographs, coaching by the club coaches and, of course, Carling and club merchandise (www.carlinglovefootball.com). While NTL had other football sponsorships in England, they did not make this intense effort to associate the company with the game itself. In Glasgow Carling has not confined itself to football, but has also set up the Carling Academy, a Glasgow music venue. It also joined forces with the Celtic and Rangers managers to promote a sensible drinking message through television advertising aired over the Christmas and New Year period for 2003–2004 and is the first alcohol sponsor to offer a children's unbranded version of the replica team shirt. This is likely to heighten goodwill towards the company, while market research shows the message

has had an impact, with 46% of male football fans saying the advertisements would encourage them to moderate their drinking (Murden, 2004). Only a month after the deal had officially begun, Carling had seen a rise in market share in Scotland from under 1% to 3.2% (Murden, 2003).

Research Questions

The response of supporters to a joint sponsorship of their preferred team and a rival team may be ambivalent. On the one hand, a positive response should be generated towards the sponsor because of their support for the preferred team. On the other hand, support of the rival team may produce alienation. In addition, responses may be affected by the perceived motivation for the joint sponsorship and may vary according to the degree of involvement with the team. However, the role of factors such as sponsor/team fit and attitude towards a sponsor should not be affected by the joint sponsorship situation. Given the exploratory nature of the project, six semi-structured interviews were conducted before finalizing the research mode. Three of the selected informants supported Celtic and three supported Rangers and they reported various levels of involvement with the football clubs. The interviews lasted between 1 and 1.5 hours. The findings were combined with the literature to produce the following hypotheses.

It was revealed that, in the context of the study, two major factors could influence involvement with the football clubs. These were involvement with football and religion. Therefore, the following can be hypothesized.

- H₁: Involvement with one of the jointly sponsored teams will be positively influenced by (a) involvement with religion and (b) involvement with football.

Supporters who are more involved with one of the rival teams are likely to be more knowledgeable about the team (Wann and Branscombe, 1993) and, thus, about the rivalry, previous problems in finding sponsors and the management's reasons for contracting to a joint sponsorship. This could persuade them of the necessity of a joint sponsorship. Knowledge of the telecommunications industry and NTL may also convince supporters of the soundness of joint sponsorship as a business decision. This leads to the next hypothesis.

- H₂: The perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship is positively influenced by (a) involvement with one of the jointly sponsored teams and (b) involvement with the sponsor's product category

Perceptions of whether the sponsorship is necessary and welcomed appear to affect opinions of the sponsor. Perceived fit has been shown to have a positive relationship with attitude towards a sponsor (Roy and Graeff, 2002) and with sponsor image enhancement (e.g. Gwinner and Eaton, 1999). Consumers who have a negative attitude towards sponsorship are more likely to view the joint sponsorship cynically as being purely commercially motivated (Lee *et al.*, 1997), while those with a more positive attitude may credit the sponsor with some degree of sincerity in

promoting harmony between the clubs. This would suggest that positive attitudes towards sponsorship should lead to enhanced levels of response. Therefore the following set of hypotheses is proposed.

- H₃: A positive change in opinion of the sponsor will be created by (a) the perceived necessity of joint sponsorship, (b) the perceived fit between the sponsor and team, (c) a positive attitude towards sponsorship of football clubs and (d) non-rejection of the joint sponsorship.

Madrigal (2001) showed that beliefs about sponsorship had a direct effect on purchase intentions and found team identification to be positively related to attitude towards purchasing products, which in turn was positively related to purchase intentions. However, Jenkins and Fleming (2002) also found a negative relationship between team identification and purchase intention regarding a rival sponsor's products. In the joint sponsorship situation, there are both positive and negative forces acting on purchase intention. Therefore the following set of hypotheses is proposed.

- H₄: The overall attitude towards the joint sponsor brand and purchase intentions will be (a) positively influenced by the perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship, (b) negatively influenced by the rejection of joint sponsorship, (c) positively influenced by the involvement with the football club, (d) positively influenced by the changed opinion towards the sponsor and (e) positively influenced by the fit between the sponsor and the football club.

An initial model of sponsorship effects is proposed, based on these hypotheses, as indicated in Fig. 1.

Study Design

Data Collection

The sampling frame consisted of all Celtic and Rangers fans. A total of 250 questionnaires were administered across various parts of Central Scotland over a 4-week period. Data were collected from a university campus, the street and five public houses, two of which were affiliated to each team and one of which was independent. In total 185 usable questionnaires were collected (Table 2). Due to the special nature of the study, in this analysis only the 148 questionnaires from Celtic and Rangers fans were used.

Measures

Six semi-structured interviews were conducted before the development of the research instrument. Three of the selected informants supported Celtic and three supported Rangers and they reported various levels of involvement with the football club. These interviews aimed to investigate views of the joint sponsorship in order to

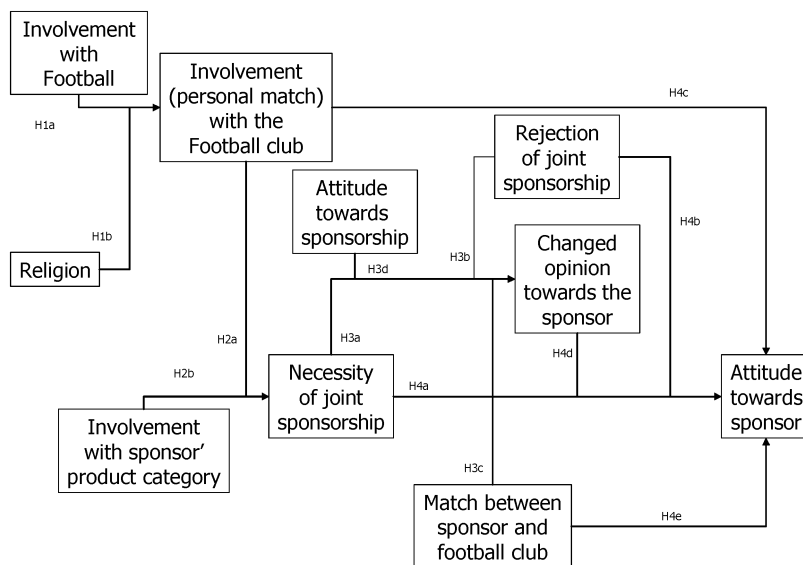


Figure 1. The initial model

Table 2. The sample

	Celtic		Rangers		Other		Total	
	<i>n</i>	%	<i>n</i>	%	<i>n</i>	%	<i>n</i>	%
Gender								
Male	67	87	57	80	28	76	152	82
Female	9	12	14	20	9	24	32	17
Not stated	1	1	0	0	0	0	1	1
Age (years)								
16–25	26	34	25	35	20	54	71	38
26–30	10	13	11	16	4	11	25	14
31–35	9	12	15	21	0	0	24	13
36–40	11	14	8	11	10	27	29	16
41–45	10	13	7	10	3	8	20	11
46–50	2	3	0	0	0	0	2	1
51–55	5	6	3	4	0	0	8	4
56–65	4	5	2	3	0	0	6	3
Education								
High school	29	38	22	31	9	24	60	32
HND/HNC	8	10	16	23	0	0	24	13
BA/MA	33	43	28	39	22	60	83	45
Postgraduate	7	9	5	7	6	16	18	10
Total	77	100	71	100	37	100	185	100

attempt to examine the suitability of the constructs under investigation in this context, to develop scales where appropriate measures were not available and to assess the suitability of the chosen scales in this context.

The questionnaire was drafted and pilot tested to 25 respondents of different ages, gender and educational backgrounds. It was well received and was considered to be both appropriate in its presentation and insightful into the respondents' mindset. All constructs were operationalized using five-point Likert-type scales and are shown in Table 3. More specifically, the final measures were as follows.

Involvement with football. This was measured with six items.

- (1) I have a great interest in football.
- (2) Football is fascinating.
- (3) I have a compulsive need to know more about football.
- (4) I am crazy about football.
- (5) I like football.
- (6) I like to engage in conversations about football.

The scale was adapted from one used previously by Srinivasan and Ratchford (1991) and characterized as reliable, with an α coefficient of 0.86 for the scale.

Religion and the football team. This was measured with two items specifically developed for this project.

- (1) Supporting (the football team) ought to be important to me because of my religious beliefs.
- (2) Supporting (the football team) reinforces my beliefs.

Table 3. Reliability analysis of the study variables

	Number of items	Mean	SD	Reliability analysis
Involvement with football	6	4.18	0.79	0.86 ^a
Religion and the football team	2	2.67	1.43	0.56 ^b
Involvement (personal match) with the football club	5	3.05	0.98	0.87 ^a
Involvement with the sponsor's product category	3	2.16	0.98	0.85 ^a
Perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship	1	3.01	1.25	N/A
Rejection of joint sponsorship	2	2.45	1.23	0.69 ^b
Changed opinion towards the sponsor	3	2.21	0.78	0.67 ^a
Fit between sponsor and football club	2	2.16	1.00	0.83 ^b
Attitude towards sponsorship	1	2.68	1.10	N/A
Attitude towards the sponsor	3	2.10	1.07	0.95 ^a

1, strongly disagree; 5, strongly agree.

^aCronbach's α coefficient.

^bPearson correlation.

Involvement (personal match) with the football club. This was measured with five items adapted from a scale used previously by Lastovica *et al.* (1990), who reported an α coefficient of 0.86 for the scale. Although the original scale consists of nine items, only five of them were considered to be appropriate by the informants during the initial stages of the development of the questionnaire.

- (1) Supporting (the football team) allows others to see me as I would ideally like them to see me.
- (2) Supporting (the football team) is associated with my lifestyle.
- (3) Supporting (the football team) helps me define and express 'me' and 'I' within myself.
- (4) Supporting (the football team) is important to me because of my personal values.
- (5) Supporting (the football team) is important to me because of what others think.

Involvement with the sponsor's product category. This was measured with three items used by Cole and Balasubramanian (1993) for investigating familiarity with and interest in a product category. They reported an α coefficient of 0.71.

- (1) Compared to other people, I know more about telecommunications.
- (2) I am very interested in telecommunications.
- (3) My friends consider me an expert on telecommunications.

Perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship. This was measured with one item specifically developed for this project: having the same sponsor is necessary.

Rejection of joint sponsorship. This was measured with two items developed for this project.

- (1) It annoys me that Celtic and Rangers have the same sponsor.
- (2) It would be better if Celtic and Rangers had differing sponsors.

Changed opinion towards the sponsor. This was measured with three items developed for this project.

- (1) I am more willing to buy NTL products because it sponsors both teams.
- (2) The fact that NTL sponsors Celtic and Rangers makes me think that it is of high quality.
- (3) I am willing to pay more for a brand sponsoring both teams.

Fit between sponsor and football club. This was measured with two items developed for this project.

- (1) NTL and Celtic have similar values and beliefs.
- (2) NTL and Rangers have similar values and beliefs.

Attitude towards sponsorship. This was measured with nine items developed for this project.

- (1) It is increasing in relation to what it used to be.
- (2) It provides useful information.

- (3) It is often deceptive.
- (4) Is something I ignore.
- (5) It provides financial resources to clubs.
- (6) It is necessary.
- (7) It is very annoying.
- (8) I enjoy it.
- (9) It should be more closely regulated.

Attitude towards (preference for) the sponsor. This was measured with three items chosen and adapted from the four items used by Sirgy *et al.* (1991).

- (1) I like NTL better than other similar companies.
- (2) I would consider or I use NTL's products more than I would consider or I use the products of other similar companies.
- (3) NTL is my preferred brand over other similar brands.

Data Analysis

Before the performance of any statistical tests, certain computations were performed and the data were prepared for the rest of the analysis. All the variables of the study were essentially perceptual and therefore subject to a respondent's filtering process. Objective instruments for the measurement of the constructs were unavailable. Thus, Cronbach's α coefficient was used for testing for internal consistency. The average value reported for each of the product categories was calculated and used for the various tests.

In addition to the descriptive statistics, other statistical techniques were used. Stepwise linear regression analysis was applied for identifying the variables predicting the dependent variables. In order to control the variables of multicollinearity, the variance inflation factor was calculated. The degree of multicollinearity was not considered as problematic, since the variance inflation factor values were all below 10, which is the benchmark suggested by Neter *et al.* (1990).

Results

All the scales used in the study can be considered reliable, since the dimensions of the multi-items constructs measured had α reliability coefficients very closely in excess of 0.70 or a high and positive Pearson correlation (Table 3). Therefore it can be argued that all items were indeed measuring the same construct.

Factor analysis was attempted on the attitude and belief statements regarding football club sponsorship, but the three factors obtained had very low scale reliability. Therefore correlations with each individual statement were examined. Only the statement that sponsorship 'provides useful information' had a significant (positive) correlation with changed opinion towards the sponsor.

The correlations for the constructs under investigation are reported in Table 4. Perceived fit influences joint sponsorship similarly to single sponsorship.

The correlation of involvement with necessity was negative and significant at the 0.01 level and the correlation with rejection of joint sponsorship was positive and

Table 4. Pearson inter-correlation coefficients of the study variables

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
A Involvement with football	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
B Religion and the football team	0.40 ^a	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
C Involvement (personal match) with the football club	0.52 ^a	0.68 ^a	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
D Involvement with the sponsor’s product category	0.04	0.35 ^a	0.16 ^b	–	–	–	–	–	–
E Perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship	–0.12	–0.16	–0.34 ^a	0.21 ^a	–	–	–	–	–
F Rejection of joint sponsorship	–0.06	0.23 ^a	0.17 ^b	0.00	–0.10	–	–	–	–
G Changed opinion towards the sponsor	–0.10	0.13	0.03	0.18 ^b	0.39 ^a	0.16 ^b	–	–	–
H Fit between sponsor and football club	–0.22 ^a	–0.28 ^a	–0.16 ^b	–0.09	0.19 ^b	0.17 ^b	0.21 ^a	–	–
I Attitude towards sponsorship	–0.10	0.02	–0.07	0.10	0.02	–0.04	0.35 ^a	0.05	–
J Attitude towards the sponsor	–0.16 ^b	0.02	–0.06	0.06	0.25 ^a	0.27 ^a	0.53 ^a	0.56 ^a	0.11

^aSignificant at the 0.01 level.

^bSignificant at the 0.05 level.

significant at the 0.05 level. It appears that either the most committed supporters do not accept the rationale for a joint sponsorship or that their emotional attachment to the team (and corresponding antipathy to their rivals) outweighs any rational argument in favour of joint sponsorship.

The correlation of necessity with changed opinion was positive and significant at the 0.01 level, while that of rejection of joint sponsorship with changed opinion was also positive and significant, but at the 0.05 level only. It seems that those who were annoyed by the joint sponsorship and would prefer different sponsors nonetheless have more positive opinions about NTL, maybe due to an appreciation of NTL supporting their favoured team.

There was a positive correlation, which was significant at the 0.01 level, between the necessity of joint sponsorship and brand preference for the sponsor and also with the individual statement relating to willingness to buy NTL in preference to other brands. None of the attitude and belief statements regarding football club sponsorship in general showed a significant correlation with a preference for NTL and their products.

There was no correlation, positive or negative, between involvement with Celtic or Rangers and preference for NTL. However, interestingly, a preference for NTL was positively associated with both the perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship and rejection of it.

Involvement with the football club (either Celtic or Rangers) was found to be predicted by involvement with football and the extent to which supporting one of these teams was bound up with religious beliefs. Involvement with the telecommunications industry was positively associated (0.01 significance level) with taking notice of football club sponsorship and also with perceiving the joint sponsorship as necessary.

The hypothesized links among the study variables were examined during the analysis. When the path analysis was constructed, some of the proposed relationships were proved to be very insignificant. It was decided that only the statistically significant relationships among variables at the 0.05 level should be included in the final model. Therefore, a series of backward regressions were carried out. The revised framework is presented in Fig. 2.

Although the variables were inter-correlated, regression analysis could be performed in this data set, since the degree of multi-collinearity could not be considered as problematic. All tolerance values were greater than 0.02 and all variance inflation factor values were under 5 (Table 4). Most of the regression analyses were statistically significant ($\alpha=0.00$) and showed very strong explanatory power, since the R^2 -values ranged from 0.15 to 0.53 (Table 5), indicating that a 15–53% of the variation of the dependent variables was explained by taking into account the suggested independent variables.

Although not all the hypothesized links in the path were supported, those that were supported seemed to be relatively strong (Table 6). Both the involvement with football and religion were proven to be good predictors of the involvement with the football club and, thus, hypotheses H_{1a} and H_{1b} were supported. The involvement with the football club had a significant but negative link with the perceived necessity of the joint sponsorship and, therefore, H_{2a} was rejected, while the involvement with

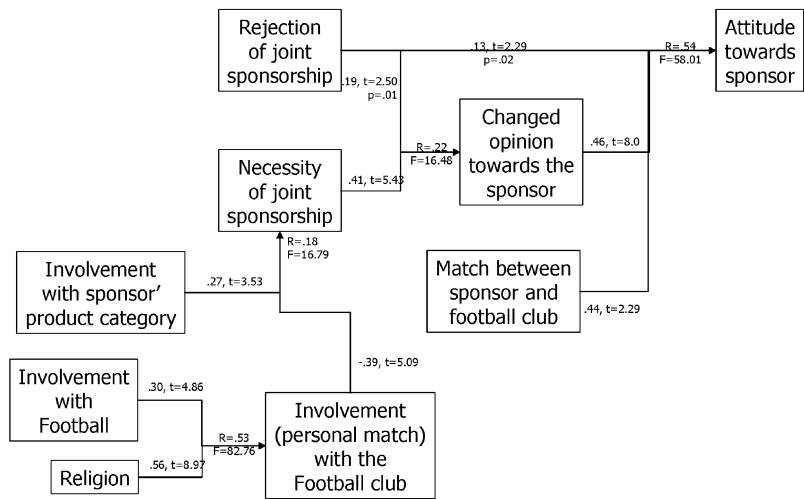


Figure 2. The revised model

the sponsor's product category had a positive and significant relationship and H_{2b} was supported.

The best predictors of the changed opinion towards the sponsor were the perceived fit of the sponsor with the football club and attitude towards the sponsorship. Therefore, H_{3c} and H_{3d} were supported. The overall attitude towards the sponsor was better predicted by the perceived fit of the sponsor with the football club, the changed opinion towards the sponsor and, to a lesser extent, by the rejection of joint sponsorship. Thus, hypotheses H_{4b} , H_{4d} and H_{4e} were supported.

Attitude towards sponsorship (in general) was found not to be significant in this case and was therefore omitted entirely from the model. Lee *et al.* (1997), whose studies focused on global sporting events rather than teams, suggested this variable. It appears that the effects of team loyalty in this study override any

Table 5. Reported R^2 -values and F -statistics: dependents

Dependent	R^2	F -statistic
Original model		
H_1 Involvement (personal match) with the football club	0.53	82.8 ^a
H_2 Necessity of the joined sponsorship	0.18	16.8 ^a
H_3 Changed opinion towards the sponsor	0.15	8.9 ^a
H_4 Attitude towards the sponsor	0.44	27.8 ^a
Revised model		
H_1 Involvement (personal match) with the football club	0.53	82.8 ^a
H_2 Necessity of the joined sponsorship	0.18	16.8 ^a
H_3 Changed opinion towards the sponsor	0.15	26.1 ^a
H_4 Attitude towards the sponsor	0.44	47.1 ^a

^aSignificant at the 0.001 level.

Table 6. Hypothesized path results: independents

Independent		Standardized β	t	Tolerance	Variance inflation factor
Original model					
H _{1a}	Involvement with football	0.30	4.86 ^a	0.84	1.19
H _{1b}	Religion and the football team	0.56	8.97 ^a	0.84	1.19
H _{2a}	Involvement with the football club	-0.39	-5.09 ^a	0.98	1.03
H _{2b}	Involvement with sponsor's product category	0.27	3.53 ^a	0.98	1.03
H _{3a}	Necessity of the joint sponsorship	0.11	1.61	0.92	1.09
H _{3b}	Rejection of joint sponsorship	0.03	0.35	0.88	1.13
H _{3c}	Sponsor/Football club match	0.18	2.56 ^a	0.94	1.07
H _{3d}	Attitude towards sponsorship	0.34	4.91 ^a	0.99	1.01
H _{4a}	Necessity of the joint sponsorship	-0.01	-0.24	0.83	1.21
H _{4b}	Rejection of joint sponsorship	0.13	2.22 ^b	0.92	1.09
H _{4c}	Involvement with the football club	0.01	0.21	0.90	1.11
H _{4d}	Changed opinion toward sponsor	0.40	6.65 ^a	0.87	1.14
H _{4e}	Sponsor/Football club match	0.42	7.14 ^a	0.91	1.10
Revised model					
H _{1a}	Involvement with football	0.30	4.86 ^a	0.84	1.19
H _{1b}	Religion and the football team	0.56	8.97 ^a	0.84	1.19
H _{2a}	Involvement with the football club	-0.39	-5.09 ^a	0.98	1.03
H _{2b}	Involvement with sponsor's product category	0.27	3.53 ^a	0.98	1.03
H _{3a}	Necessity of the joint sponsorship	—	—	—	—
H _{3b}	Rejection of joint sponsorship	—	—	—	—
H _{3c}	Sponsor/Football club match	0.17	2.56 ^a	1.00	1.00
H _{3d}	Attitude towards sponsorship	0.34	4.93 ^a	1.00	1.00
H _{4a}	Necessity of the joint sponsorship	—	—	—	—
H _{4b}	Rejection of joint sponsorship	0.13	2.35 ^b	0.96	1.04
H _{4c}	Involvement with the football club	—	—	—	—
H _{4d}	Changed opinion toward sponsor	0.39	6.95 ^a	0.96	1.04
H _{4e}	Sponsor/Football club match	0.42	7.21 ^a	0.93	1.08

^aSignificant at the 0.001 level.^bSignificant at the 0.05 level.

effects from attitudes towards sponsorship (similarly to Madrigal (2001) in predicting purchase intentions). One can argue that it only has an indirect effect on the attitude towards the sponsor, since it is the best predictor of the changed opinion towards the sponsor.

Conclusion

It would be expected and has been confirmed in previous research that committed supporters of a team will be those most affected by the sponsorship in forming a more positive image of the sponsor or intending to purchase their brand. However, sponsorship of rival teams appears to complicate this relationship to the extent that there was no positive correlation between involvement with the team and more positive attitudes towards or preferences for NTL. The more involved

supporters were with either Celtic or Rangers, the less necessity they saw for a joint sponsorship, but it was supporters who perceived the necessity of the joint sponsorship who were more likely to change their attitudes and brand preferences in favour of NTL. However, more committed supporters are also more likely to reject the sponsorship and rejection of the joint sponsorship is also positively though less strongly associated with changes in attitudes and brand preferences. There seemed to be a fine balance of positive and negative feelings towards NTL among those supporters with greater emotional involvement, while for those who were able to consider the situation more rationally, accepting the need for a joint sponsor, the response was more positively weighted. This is a clear contrast to the single sponsorship situation.

The study therefore shows ambivalence on the part of committed Celtic and Rangers supporters regarding their attitudes towards NTL. This may explain why, although the sponsorship created the desired awareness of the brand, it was less effective in terms of sales objectives. A further factor may be that purchases of NTL's products and services would normally be major decisions, with high involvement on the part of the consumer. This would imply that more attention would be paid to evaluating the actual product/service and competing alternatives, rather than being reliant on peripheral cues that give no direct brand information. A repetition of this study to examine and compare attitudes to the Carling sponsorship could shed light on this issue.

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